The Three Types of God's Will in the New Testament

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The New Testament speaks of God's will in three distinct senses, and the distinction is not a later theological invention — it rests on the Greek vocabulary the apostles actually used. Three words carry the weight:

Greek word	Basic sense	Which type of will it usually marks
boulē (βουλή)	counsel, purpose, decree	Sovereign will — what God has determined
thelēma (θέλημα)	will, desire, command	Moral will — what God commands and wants done
eudokia (εὐδοκία) / *thelō*	good pleasure, wish	Will of disposition — what pleases God

The words overlap in places, so the categories are drawn from how the New Testament *uses* them, not from the dictionary alone. All Scripture quotations below are from the NET Bible.

1. God's Sovereign Will (the will of decree)

This is God's eternal purpose — what He has determined *will* happen. It cannot be thwarted, is often hidden until it unfolds, and includes even the acts of those who oppose Him.

Anchor text: "In Christ we too have been claimed as God's own possession, since we were predestined according to the one purpose of him who accomplishes all things according to the counsel of his will" (Ephesians 1:11).

Supporting texts:

- The cross itself was decreed: Jesus was "handed over by the predetermined plan and foreknowledge of God" (Acts 2:23) — yet carried out by wicked hands.
- Every human plan is subject to it: "If the Lord is willing, then we will live and do this or that" (James 4:15).
- God "does as he pleases" and no one can stay His hand (Daniel 4:35; cf. Isaiah 46:10).

Key feature: It is always accomplished. Nothing in history falls outside it — including the crucifixion, which men committed in sin and God had purposed for salvation.

2. God's Moral Will (the will of precept, or revealed will)

This is what God *commands* and desires of His people — His revealed instructions for how to live. Unlike the sovereign will, this one *can* be disobeyed, and constantly is. In this sense it is the "will of God" most often meant when the New Testament tells believers to *do* it.

Anchor text: "For this is God's will: that you become holy, that you keep away from sexual immorality" (1 Thessalonians 4:3).

Supporting texts:

- "In everything give thanks. For this is God's will for you in Christ Jesus" (1 Thessalonians 5:18).
- Entry into the kingdom belongs to "the one who does the will of my Father in heaven" (Matthew 7:21).
- The renewed mind exists to "test and approve what is the will of God — what is good and well-pleasing and perfect" (Romans 12:2).
- "Do not be foolish, but be wise by understanding what the Lord's will is" (Ephesians 5:17).

Key feature: It is fully revealed in Scripture. You do not have to hunt for it; it is written down. This is the will that the *obedience of faith* answers to.

3. God's Will of Disposition (the will of desire, or good pleasure)

This is what *pleases* God — His heart's disposition toward people, expressed even where it is not sovereignly decreed to occur. Here Scripture says God "wants" or "wishes" something that does not in every case come to pass.

Anchor text: "The Lord is not slow concerning his promise… but is being patient toward you, because he does not wish for any to perish but for all to come to repentance" (2 Peter 3:9).

Supporting texts:

- God "wants all people to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth" (1 Timothy 2:4).
- The Old Testament background: "I take no pleasure in the death of the wicked" (Ezekiel 33:11).

- Jesus wept over Jerusalem: "How often I have longed to gather your children together… but you would have none of it" (Matthew 23:37).

Key feature: It reveals God's *character* behind His commands. Because not all are saved, this cannot be the sovereign decree — yet it is genuinely God's desire. It keeps the first two from being misread as cold: the God who decrees and commands is also the God who grieves and invites.

How the three fit together

A single event can involve all three at once. At Gethsemane Jesus prays, "not what I will, but what you will" (Matthew 26:39) — submitting His own desire to the Father's decree. The cross He faces is simultaneously decreed (the sovereign will, Acts 2:23), carried out by men violating God's commands (the moral will disobeyed), and the supreme expression of God's desire to save (the will of disposition, John 3:16).

For the *Obedience of Faith* course, the mapping is clean:

Type of will	Where it lives in the course	What it means for the believer
Sovereign will	The ground of grace — "mercy first" (Week 4; Hebrews 10:10)	The finished work no one earns
Moral will	Where the obedience of faith lives (Romans 1:5; 16:26)	The revealed commands faith hears and does
Will of disposition	The heart behind both (Romans 2:4)	Why obedience is a thank offering, not a payment

Obedience answers the moral will, rests on the sovereign will, and is motivated by the will of disposition — a God who wishes none to perish is not keeping score.

A note on terminology

Some popular teaching substitutes a third category called God's "individual will" — a specific, hidden plan for each person's decisions (which job, which house, which spouse) that the believer must discover through signs, impressions, or inner peace.

That framing is not the classical three, and it has been seriously questioned. Garry Friesen's *Decision Making and the Will of God* (1980; rev. 2004) is the standard critique. His argument: Scripture never commands

us to find a hidden personal blueprint. It commands us to obey the *revealed* moral will and, within it, to make wise decisions with the freedom God grants (1 Corinthians 7:39, “only in the Lord”; Romans 14).

The payoff of the classical three is relief: God’s will for your life is not a needle hidden in a haystack. It is written down, it rests on His finished work, and it flows from a heart that desires your good.